Critical Rhetorical Skills for TPC Students:
Teaching *with*, *for*, and *against* AI-generated text

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Preview of upcoming talk

1. Teaching context and “With, For, Against” Framework
2. Teaching how LLMs actually write (*against*)
3. Genre-based exercises relevant to TPC (*with*)

The course I'll be discussing is ENGL 288, which has 3 major projects over a 10-week quarter…

1. Professionalization (job market materials, incl. cover letter)
2. Instructional design (software or other instruction manual)
3. Change proposal (local community-based, team-based)

In forthcoming work, I articulate my pedagogy for critical AI literacy, which consists of the following:

A. **teaching *against* "AI"**: readings, lectures, and activities that help students understand the technology and critique it

B. **teaching *for* "AI"**: activities in which students imagine intervening to make the technology more ethical

C. **teaching *with* "AI"**: guided and scaffolded experiments with the technology as learning and communication tools

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C. **teaching *with* "AI"**: guided and scaffolded experiments with the technology as learning and communication tools

To teach against AI-generated text for TPC students, we can assign students readings on how LLMs actually write**.**

Use readings such as:

- Markey, B., Brown, D. W., Laudenbach, M., & Kohler, A. (2024). Dense and disconnected: Analyzing the sedimented style of ChatGPT-generated text at scale. *Written Communication*, 41(4), 571-600.

- Reinhart, A., Markey, B., Laudenbach, M., Pantusen, K., Yurko, R., Weinberg, G., & Brown, D. W. (2025). Do LLMs write like humans? Variation in grammatical and rhetorical styles. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 122(8), e2422455122.

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- Markey, B., Brown, D. W., Laudenbach, M., & Kohler, A. (2024). Dense and disconnected.
  - ➢ LLM-generated text is comparatively “dense and disconnected”, “dialogically closed”, “empty”, and “fluffy”
    - ❖ manifests in “more *attributive adjectives*, *nouns*, and *prepositions*”, “a **higher rate of grammatical transformation** from other parts of speech into nouns, such as through *nominalizations, participles, and gerunds*”, “**fewer hedges** and **modals of possibility**”

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- Markey, B., Brown, D. W., Laudenbach, M., & Kohler, A. (2024). Dense and disconnected.
  - ➢ also finds that LLMs struggle at "**generating pedestrian examples**" to help clarify abstract concepts

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  - "large differences in grammatical, lexical, and stylistic features": using "*present participial clauses* at **2 to 5 times** the rate of human text" and "*nominalizations* at **1.5 to 2 times** the rate of humans", while using "the *agentless passive voice* at roughly **half** the rate as human texts"

    - significantly less *clausal co-ordination* in two out of three LLMs analyzed (exception: Llama???)

To teach against AI-generated text for TPC students, we can draw from these readings to discuss how LLMs actually write.

Feature Difference	LLM-coded example	Human-coded example
Attributive adjectives/nouns	“comprehensive regional transportation infrastructure plan”	“plan for transportation in the region”
Nominalizations	“evaluation of performance”	“evaluate how it performs”
Fewer hedges	“The model demonstrates improvement.”	“The model may demonstrate improvement.”
More participial clauses	“an event producing unexpectedly high readings…”	“[X happened] and it produced unexpectedly high readings”
Less agentless passive	“Researchers measured the samples.”	“The samples were measured.”
Less clausal coordination	“three-phase development framework”	“a framework was developed in three phases, and it explains…”

Exercise demo: AI slop style vs. a more human style

- **https://cpollak-uw.github.io/ai-style-exercises/**
  - Exercise set 1 includes side-by-side paragraphs roughly approximating each style, across three disciplines
  - Students are given sample sentences to match to the styles and other samples to revise and improve

Exercise demo: Spotting and revising AI slop across genres

- **https://cpollak-uw.github.io/ai-style-exercises/**
  - Exercise set 2 is broken up into cover letters, instructions, and proposals
  - Students are given sample sentences to identify, revise, and analyze in these different genres

Chatbot demo: Interactive exercises and textual revision tool

- **https://cpollak-uw.github.io/ai-style-exercises/**
  - Chatbot allows students to do the same exercises interactively
  - Also enables students to enter text and ask for revisions according to principles of “more human style”
    - Tested with GPT-generated cover letter, proposal, and instructions, and it did a pretty good job

What comes next

- I'd like to flesh these three resources out with more real examples and richer analyses
- I wonder if I'm scoping the classification of "AI slop" vs. "more human style" too narrowly and/or if there are more features that could be added to either bucket (e.g. punctuation, examples, narrative details, source engagement)
- Haven't used this in class yet, but I plan to soon and will report back in a journal or online publication
- I'd love your feedback on the work so far!

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Questions?

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Email me!